grown into a large international enterprise with a presence in 125 countries of various geographies and a global network covering ‘over 8,800 touch points’. Its revenue in 2022 was larger than that of Coca-Cola that was ranked 93 in the *Fortune* 500 list of US companies.

As of 31 March 2022, Tata Motors had 73,608 employees, which is more than the population of most Class-II cities of India. It is India’s largest automobile company and became its first indigenous car manufacturer to promote the nation’s nationalistic ‘Make in India’ policy, incidentally decades before the idea was picked up by the government. It is also the nation’s largest original equipment manufacturer (OEM) of indigenously designed cars. Besides, Tata Motors is the second-largest private company in the country in terms of revenue (2022).

It was Sumant Moolgaokar who laid the foundation of TELCO and made it the largest manufacturer of commercial vehicles in India. He was the ‘main driving force and visionary in TELCO for 45 years’, and he built the company, said Ratan. Before the liberalization policy of 1991, the company had flourished in the protected environment of the Licence Raj, largely insulated from competition. During Moolgaokar’s last years, TELCO’s performance had, however, slipped on account of his indisposition and the worst labour unrest in the group’s history. In the last two years before Ratan took over (FY 1986–87 and FY 1987–88), the aggregate PAT declined by nearly 24 per cent in comparison to the previous two years.

When Ratan succeeded Moolgaokar, it marked the beginning of a new era for the company. He quickly implemented a host of reforms, particularly after he became group chairman. Many of them were the main pillars of his restructuring programme for the group. He gave it ‘10–15 years of head start … [without him], Tata Motors [would have been] weak in the marketplace; it would have lost its dominance. He changed the vision of Tata Motors—gave it a vision for the twenty-first century’, said Prakash Telang, former MD of the India operations of Tata Motors.

Ratan’s first emphasis was on modernization and upgradation of technology to benchmark the company’s products to international standards. As part of this, he focused on creating a new ‘design criteria for TELCO’s products’ and made ‘substantial investments in new manufacturing techniques, processes and quality control’. These initiatives were not only aimed at capturing a bigger share of the domestic market but also aimed to give the Indian customer vehicles of higher quality.